

Socialism and communism



Combining his economic analysis of the prevailing capitalist system with a dialectical view of history, Marx developed a basis for his revolutionary political philosophy. The antagonism between capitalists and the proletariat would eventually produce a synthesis, which he believed would culminate in a classless society under communism. This change would be a result of the continued alienation of the workers, but would be precipitated by what he saw as the inherent instability of the capitalist system. While recognizing capitalism's potential for economic growth, Marx pointed out that it was characterized by periodic crises and depressions that cause mass

unemployment. These would eventually lead to its collapse, he said, in a revolution transferring power from a 'dictatorship of the bourgeoisie' to a 'dictatorship of the proletariat' in which means of production would be controlled by the workers. For Marx, this socialist 'workers' democracy' was likewise a stage in the progression towards communism, a classless, stateless society with no private property.